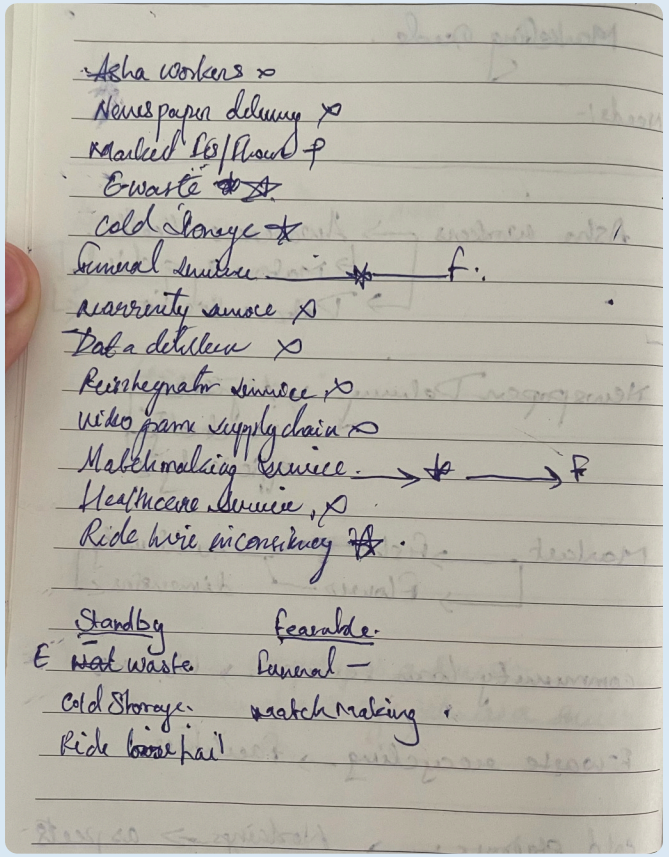
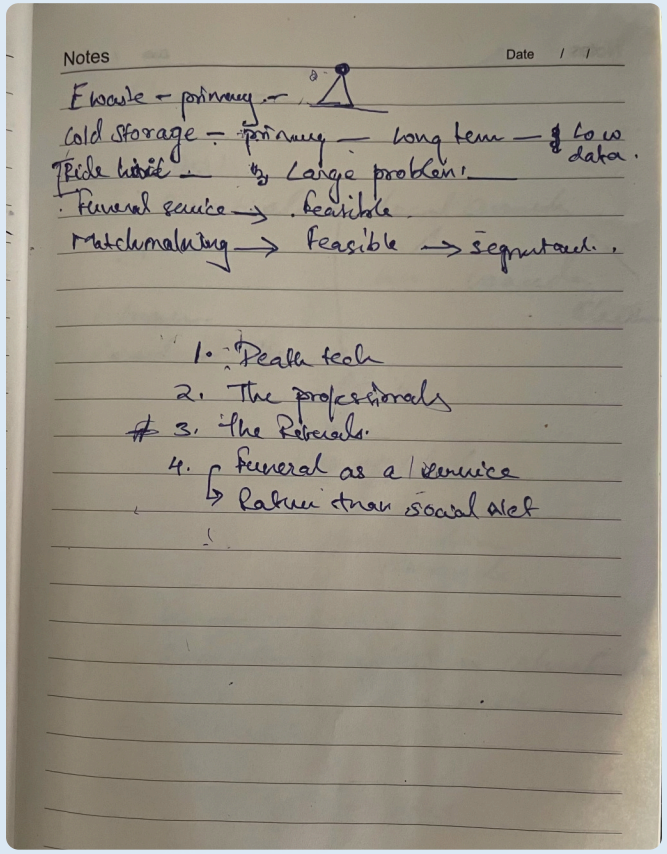
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by Moulik Nanda & Sudarsinii Mazumdar

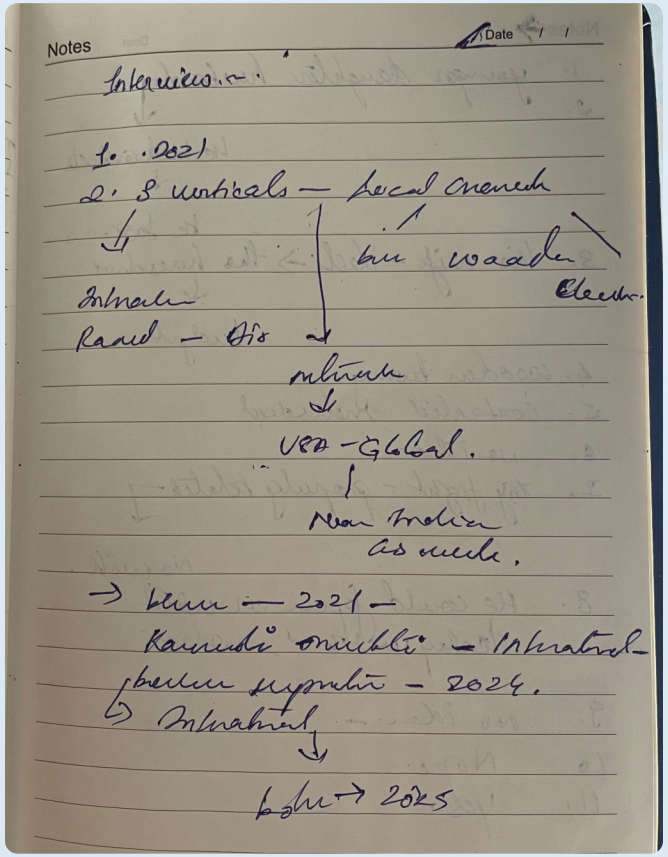
Ideation on Topics



Started off by coming up with 4-5 ideas per person to pick from



Narrowing down ideas based on potential and viability and deeper look into funeral services



Coming up with a research methodology to further explore funeral services

Secondary Research

Here are some more documents of us doing some preliminary research on funerals as a service in india ans how it ned us to our line of inquiry.



Death tech
https://anthyesti.com/-
customercare@anthyesti.com

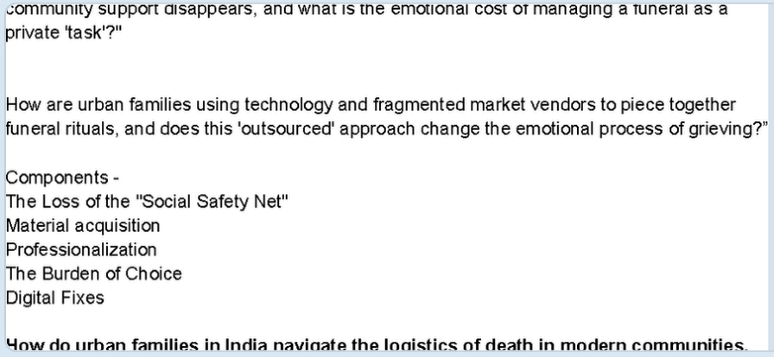
https://beleiv.com/-
madhu@beleiv.com

https://www.lastjourney.in/-
https://www.linkedin.com/in/rishabh-jalan-808247125/

https://kaashimukthi.com/-
madhu@beleiv.com

preliminary research.pdf

58.3 KB



community support disappears, and what is the emotional cost of managing a funeral as a private 'task'?"

How are urban families using technology and fragmented market vendors to piece together funeral rituals, and does this 'outsourced' approach change the emotional process of grieving?"

Components -
The Loss of the "Social Safety Net"
Material acquisition
Professionalization
The Burden of Choice
Digital Fixes

How do urban families in India navigate the logistics of death in modern communities,

loi.pdf

44.4 KB

Literature Study

For our literature study stage, we looked into the following 15 research papers:-

1. From Ritual Mourning to Solitary Grief: Reinterpretation of Hindu Death Rituals in India

Focusing on the COVID-19 pandemic as a major disruptor, this study examines how urban families in Kerala and West Bengal navigated strict biomedical protocols. It details how state-mandated rules (sealed body bags, electronic cremations) forced families to modify sacred rites, leading to intense distress and the rise of "COVID ritual brokers" who charged high fees to negotiate with hospital or crematorium staff.

2. Architecture of Death: Multifaith Burial and Cemetery Centre

Focusing on urban spatial constraints, this architectural research proposes "vertical cemeteries" (high-rise buildings) as a solution for the severe lack of land in metropolitan areas. It details how different faiths dictate different disposal methods (cremation, burial, sky burial) and argues that modern urban infrastructure must innovatively stack these spaces. Furthermore, it emphasizes the psychological role that architecture—such as lighting, scale, and materials—plays in helping families process grief during the funeral.

3. Death and bereavement in India and England: A comparative analysis

This paper compares the communal, family-led death rituals of India with the highly professionalized, individualized funeral logistics in England. It highlights the culture shock Indian families experience when trying to navigate modern Western systems, where strict crematorium time schedules, closed coffins, and mandatory funeral directors clash with the spontaneous, open, and community-driven nature of traditional Hindu rites.

4. Death in Indian Tradition – An Overview

This paper provides a concise overview of the religious beliefs guiding funeral rites across India's native religions: Hinduism, Buddhism, Jainism, and Sikhism. It explains the foundational belief in the separation of the soul from the body and the necessity of specific rituals (like the Hindu 13-day mourning period, the *Shraad* ceremony, or Sikh *Japji* prayers) to ensure the soul's peaceful transition. It serves as a baseline for understanding the strict religious conditions families are trying to fulfill amid modern urban constraints.

5. Dying Professions: Exploring Emotion Management among Doctors and Funeral Directors

This sociological study compares the "emotional labor" performed by doctors versus funeral directors. It notes that funeral directors employ "surface acting" to suppress their own emotions and prioritize the grief of the families they serve. While primarily focused on North America, this provides important context for understanding the psychological dynamics of the newly emerging class of professional funeral managers and startup employees handling death in urban India.

6. Funeral Services Industry, Funeral Pyres — Rites, Rituals and Green Funerals — India and Outside India

This article investigates the environmental and industry challenges associated with traditional Indian cremations. It details how traditional open-air pyres consume 50–60 million trees annually and produce significant carbon emissions. It highlights that the funeral industry is facing pressure to adopt sustainable practices, such as "green funerals" and alternative cremations, to navigate severe land shortages and environmental degradation in urban areas.

7. Final departures: Reflecting on India’s diverse funeral traditions

This book review summarizes literature on the intersection of spirituality, sociology, and modern logistics. It highlights how modern funeral conditions are impacted by social stratification, where wealthier families can afford elaborate ceremonies while marginalized communities face discrimination in accessing last rites. It also touches on the professionalization of funeral services and the growing necessity of eco-friendly crematoria to mitigate environmental damage.

8. The business of arranging funeral ceremony: Past, Present and Future in Indian perspective

This paper explores the rise of the organized "Death Care Industry" in India. It explains that due to increased migration, the rise of nuclear families, and busy urban lifestyles, families often lack the time and traditional knowledge required to arrange a funeral. In response, startups (like Mokshshil, Anthyesti, and Shradhanjali) have emerged to provide end-to-end logistical solutions, managing everything from hearse vans and priests to mortuary space and online digital legacies.

9. Have inequalities in completeness of death registration between states in India narrowed during two decades of civil registration system strengthening?

This paper focuses on a vital post-funeral logistic: the legal registration of death. It notes that while the national completeness of death registration improved from 58% in 2000 to 81% in 2018, deep inequalities remain. Proper registration is crucial for urban families to settle inheritances and insurance, yet the data shows female deaths are registered significantly less often than male deaths due to patriarchal succession norms.

10. Hindu deaths in India—Part 1

Through a detailed case study of an affluent Brahmin family in a large city, this paper maps the exact step-by-step traditional logistics of an Indian death. It describes how the domestic space is entirely transformed (moving the body to the floor, halting normal cooking), how gender roles dictate logistics (men handle the pyre and barbers, women manage home mourning), and how the extended community (*baradari*) steps in to support the family. It illustrates how funerals were historically managed organically by community networks rather than commercial entities.

11. How do Funeral Practices impact Bereaved Relatives' Mental Health, Grief and Bereavement? A Mixed Methods Review with Implications for COVID-19

This rapid review assesses the psychological impact of restrictive funeral conditions (like those seen during COVID-19). It finds that a funeral's benefit to mental health does not depend strictly on its traditional size or format, but rather on the bereaved's ability to exert control and shape the ritual into something personally meaningful. This is highly relevant to understanding how urban Indian families might adapt to digital broadcasting or shorter, restricted ceremonies.

12. End of life: What kind of funeral services would you choose for your loved ones?

This study quantitatively assesses the urban Indian consumer's willingness to outsource funeral logistics. Surveying 150 respondents, it found that over 80% consider arranging a funeral to be a "difficult" or "very difficult" task during a time of intense grief. Consequently, nearly 60% of respondents indicated they would likely outsource these arrangements to an external professional agency. The paper highlights that modern families need help with logistics, legal documentation, and emerging trends like "green funerals" and digital legacy management.

13. Restricted Mourning: Impact of the COVID-19 Pandemic on Funeral Services, Grief Rituals, and Prolonged Grief Symptoms

Surveying bereaved individuals during the pandemic, this study explores how restricted funeral logistics affect "Prolonged Grief" (PG) symptoms. Interestingly, while participants felt the restrictions were negative, the study found that altering the logistics (such as not attending in person or limiting the gathering) did not inherently worsen prolonged grief symptoms if families successfully created alternative, helpful coping rituals.

14. Burning Issues: Cremation and Incineration in Modern India

This historical analysis traces the evolution of cremation technology in India. It explains why Western "scientific" indoor crematoria struggled to replace traditional open-air wood pyres in Indian cities. For Hindus, open-air cremation remained a prestigious, ritually pure practice deeply tied to cultural identity, whereas early municipal indoor crematoria were often stigmatized as a means to dispose of unclaimed or destitute bodies.

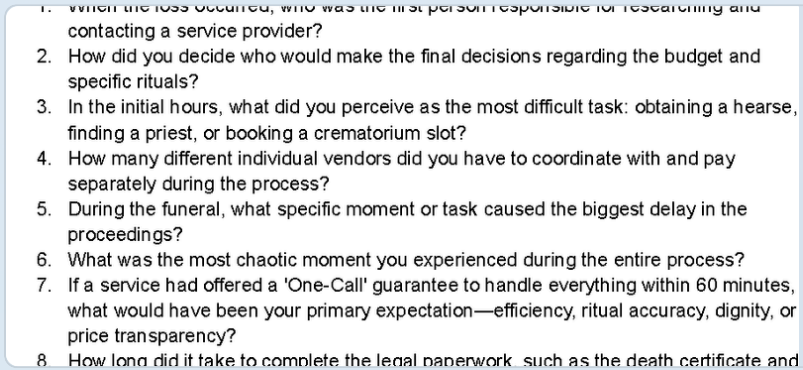
15. SPIRITUAL AND RELIGIOUS PRACTICES IN THE CONTEXT OF DISPOSAL OF THE DEAD AND ITS IMPACT; A PERSPECTIVE

This paper explores the conflict between specific spiritual practices and the medico-legal system. Looking at Uttarakhand, it notes that certain groups (saints, unmarried women, children) are traditionally given *Jal Samadhi* (water burial) or *Bhu Samadhi* (earth burial) instead of cremation. When these bodies surface or are unearthed, they place a massive administrative and investigative burden on police and forensic pathologists, demonstrating a clash between ancient logistics and modern legal conditions.

Primary Research Questionnaires/Surveys

Our next step after the literature review and secondary research was to start work on questionnaires and surveys for our Primary research, you can view the final that we came up with as following-

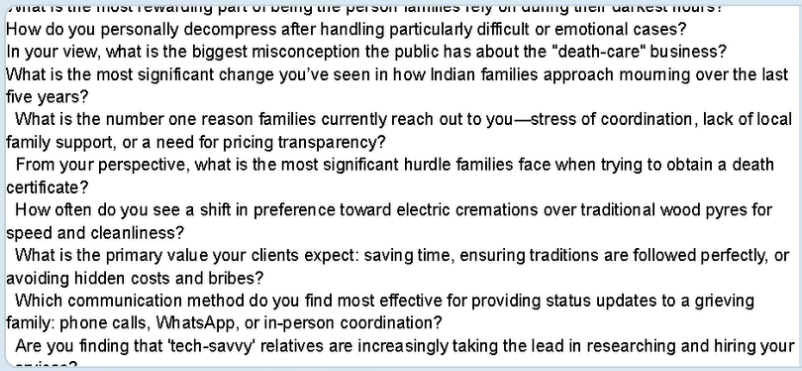
1. Questionnaire for bereaving families (qualitative)


contacting a service provider?
2. How did you decide who would make the final decisions regarding the budget and specific rituals?
3. In the initial hours, what did you perceive as the most difficult task: obtaining a hearse, finding a priest, or booking a crematorium slot?
4. How many different individual vendors did you have to coordinate with and pay separately during the process?
5. During the funeral, what specific moment or task caused the biggest delay in the proceedings?
6. What was the most chaotic moment you experienced during the entire process?
7. If a service had offered a 'One-Call' guarantee to handle everything within 60 minutes, what would have been your primary expectation—efficiency, ritual accuracy, dignity, or price transparency?
8. How long did it take to complete the legal paperwork, such as the death certificate and

families.pdf

33.5 KB

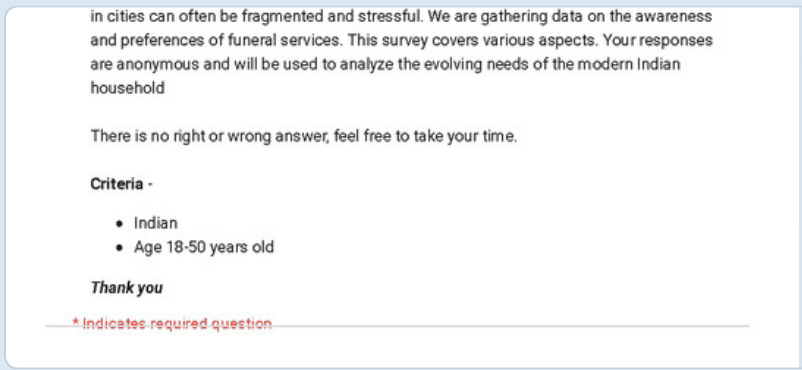
2. Questionnaire for service providers


How do you personally decompress after handling particularly difficult or emotional cases?
In your view, what is the biggest misconception the public has about the "death-care" business?
What is the most significant change you've seen in how Indian families approach mourning over the last five years?
What is the number one reason families currently reach out to you—stress of coordination, lack of local family support, or a need for pricing transparency?
From your perspective, what is the most significant hurdle families face when trying to obtain a death certificate?
How often do you see a shift in preference toward electric cremations over traditional wood pyres for speed and cleanliness?
What is the primary value your clients expect: saving time, ensuring traditions are followed perfectly, or avoiding hidden costs and bribes?
Which communication method do you find most effective for providing status updates to a grieving family: phone calls, WhatsApp, or in-person coordination?
Are you finding that 'tech-savvy' relatives are increasingly taking the lead in researching and hiring your

service providers.pdf

47.9 KB

3. Survey (quantitative)


in cities can often be fragmented and stressful. We are gathering data on the awareness and preferences of funeral services. This survey covers various aspects. Your responses are anonymous and will be used to analyze the evolving needs of the modern Indian household

There is no right or wrong answer, feel free to take your time.

Criteria -

- Indian
- Age 18-50 years old

Thank you

* Indicates required question

File upload

Survey Questions – Google Forms.pdf

180.5 KB

Why Funerals?

Before detailing our proposal in the next parts, it is important to understand the lens through which we are view this challenge. We did not approach funerals as a cold business segment, but as a Service with novelty. Our goal was to design a system that remains invisible so that seamlessness, ease and dignity remain central as they are the only things that should matter to the family.

We recognised that in the Golden Hour after a death, a family's cognitive load is at its peak. Our approach was to build a Logistical Buffer that absorbs the stress of 50+ uncoordinated phone calls.

We moved away from solutions where you owe the local broker or just opt for online one size fits all services to solutions where you are a protected consumer.

To maintain the short timeline and considering feasible data this proposal, we have defined the following boundaries:

While India sees a significant number of unnatural deaths (accidents, suicides, etc.), our documentation and service model focus exclusively on Natural Deaths (age-related, terminal illness) for the time being. This allows us to focus on the predictable transition from home/hospital to the crematorium, where professional service adds the most value.

Our narrative is rooted in the Urban Indian families, specifically addressing the breakdown of traditional community support systems in Tier-1 cities.